

Market System & *Value Chain* Map

Mapping the curriculum–labour market intelligence ecosystem in Australian higher education — the key players, how value flows between them, and where it is created, captured, and lost.

Overview

ECOSYSTEM MAP

Flow

VALUE CHAIN & THE BREAK

Deep dive

INSIDE AN LMI VENDOR

Read

WHERE VALUE IS LOST

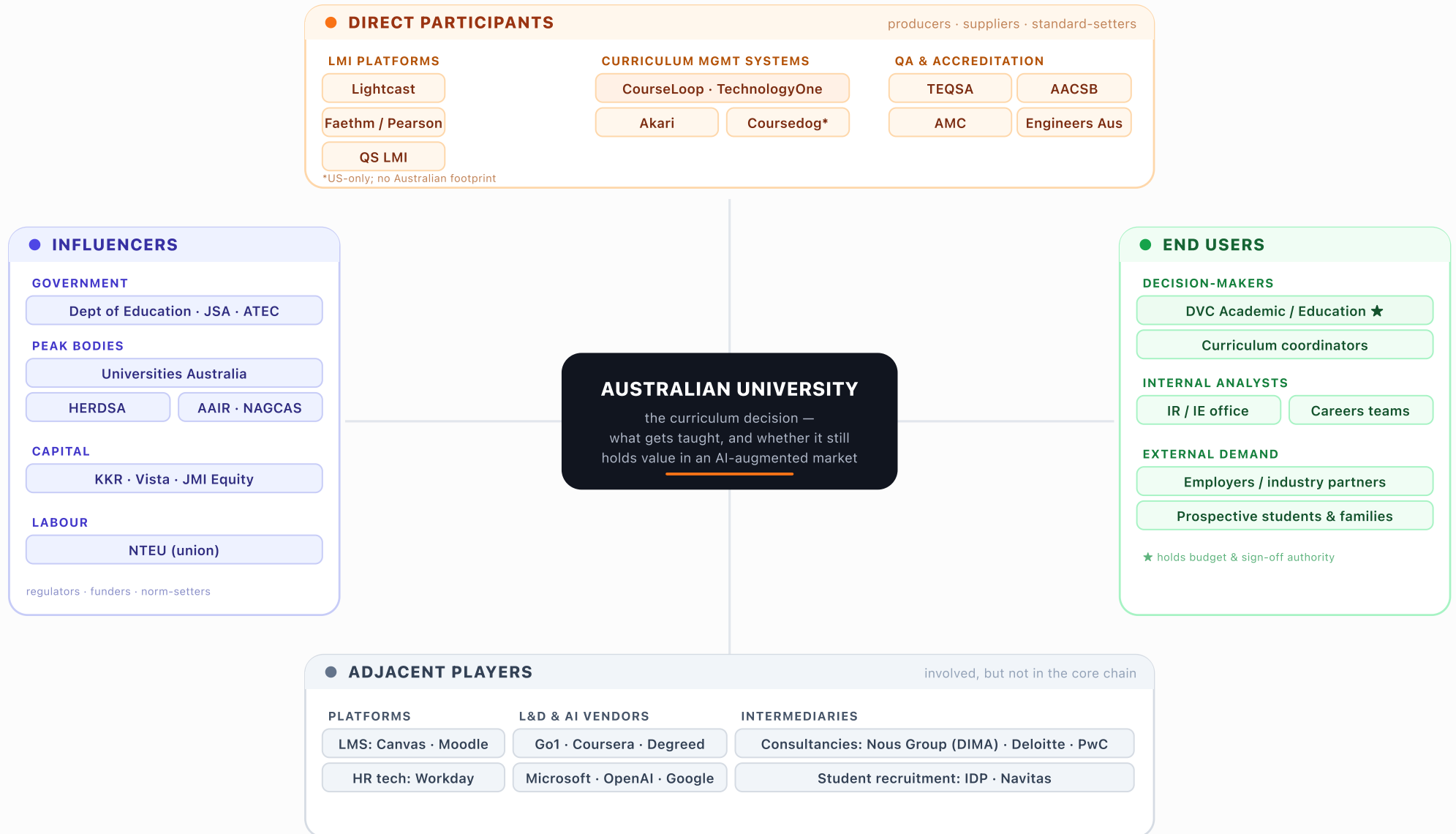
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Method MEC Define — System & value-chain mapping (Steve Blank iterative approach)

Scope Australian higher education · Labour market intelligence ↔ curriculum design

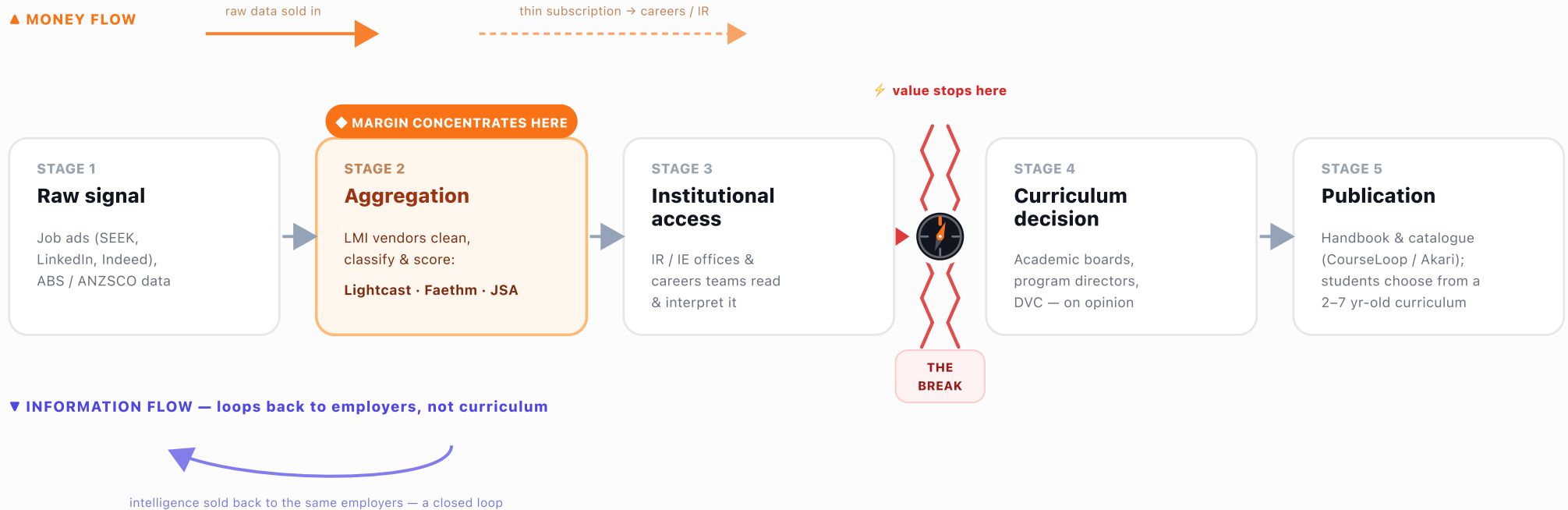
The market and its key players

A first-pass map of the ecosystem surrounding a single decision: **what a university chooses to teach**. Four groups touch that decision — direct participants who build and sell into it, influencers who shape its rules and funding, the end users who live with it, and adjacent players who orbit it.



How value flows — and where the chain breaks

Labour-market signal travels through five stages from a raw job ad to the curriculum a student enrolls in. Money concentrates early, at the **data layer**. But the chain has a structural break: intelligence reaches careers and analytics offices and **stops** — it rarely crosses into the curriculum decision itself.



VALUE LOST AT THE BREAK

- Curriculum is designed without the market signal that already exists upstream.
- No Australian curriculum-management system ingests LMI data (CourseLoop, Akari: none).
- Where LMI is bought (e.g. Melbourne since 2017) it sits in **careers**, not curriculum governance.
- 30–40% of graduates report not fully using their education (QILT GOS-L 2024) — the unpriced cost.

This break is the structural gap COMPASS is built to close — bridging Stage 3 intelligence into the Stage 4 decision.

Inside an LMI vendor — where the margin lives

Following the MEC method, a deep-dive into one organisation. The labour-market-intelligence vendor (e.g. **Lightcast**) is the system's "certifier": high margin, low capital, value built on proprietary **data and taxonomy**. Margin concentrates upstream at aggregation — and the most valuable output, reaching the curriculum, is the one part it doesn't serve.

SUPPORT ACTIVITIES — the moat

Proprietary skills & occupation taxonomy — built over two decades (the real switching cost)

Data infrastructure & AI skill-extraction models · 18B+ data points, 160+ countries

Enterprise sales, customer success & consulting · KKR-backed; serial acquisitions

PRIMARY ACTIVITIES



GROSS MARGIN INTENSITY



Margin concentrates where the work is **proprietary and non-replicable** — the data & taxonomy layer. Delivery and reporting are commoditised, low-margin.

THE UNSERVED LAST MILE — the high-margin signal never reaches the curriculum decision

WHO IT'S SOLD TO TODAY

- HR & workforce-planning teams (primary)
 - Government skills agencies (e.g. JSA)
 - University **careers** & IR offices (secondary)
- high retention, ~1% churn, strong margin

Lightcast AU footprint: Melbourne careers team since 2017

WHO IT'S NOT SOLD TO

- Curriculum coordinators & program teams
- Academic boards / curriculum governance
- No integration with CourseLoop / Akari
- Skillabi exists — but US/UK/Canada only

A genuine gap — the demand exists, but no product reaches it in Australia



THE COMPASS POSITION

Translate high-margin upstream intelligence into the one output it never reaches: a curriculum-ready, decision-grade viability signal.

Decision-support, not decision-replacement

Where value is created, captured & lost

The MEC questions, answered against the map: where is value created and captured, where is it lost, which areas look promising for a venture — and where are the tensions and untapped potential?

CREATED

Real value is created upstream, where raw job-market noise is turned into structured, scored intelligence. This is genuine, defensible knowledge work.

CAPTURED

Captured by the LMI vendor at the data & taxonomy layer — high margin, low capital, ~1% churn — and by the CMS owner (TechnologyOne) that holds the curriculum workflow.

LOST

Lost at the break between intelligence and the curriculum decision — and again downstream, borne by graduates in roles that under-use their degree. An unpriced externality.

◆ Promising area

The **last mile**: translating existing upstream intelligence into a curriculum-ready signal. The data is already produced and paid for; nobody delivers it to the curriculum decision in Australia.

The need is real and the signal already exists — the gap persists only because **no player yet translates it** into the curriculum decision.

⚖ Tensions to resolve

Demand is latent, not regulated. TEQSA polices assessment integrity, not curriculum-market durability — so adoption needs a DVC champion, not a compliance trigger.

Politics. The NTEU favours staff autonomy — a decision-*support* tool is compatible; a decision-*replacement* tool invites disputes.

Gatekeeper. TechnologyOne owns the curriculum workflow with no LMI partner — an unoccupied adjacency, and a make-or-buy question.

◇ Untapped potential

Accreditation pull. AACSB Standard 4.1 (15 AU business schools) and the AMC's 2024 digital-health standard already demand evidence of market-aligned, technology-current curricula.

Council attention. The relevance of the degree and the future of graduate jobs are now live questions at University Council — top-down demand for exactly this evidence.

No incumbent here. Skillabi & Mapademics are US-only; no Australian product exists.